

Chapter One: The Graduate and the Housemate

I graduated at forty, which sounded inspiring until people asked what I planned to do next.

The question came before I had even left the university hall.

My mother, Fe, held my face between both hands and kissed my forehead.

“You did it,” she said. “Finally.”

“Ma.”

“What?” She released my face. “It is finally done.”

My brother Jun laughed behind her. He was carrying my handbag and the container of pancit my aunt had brought for the celebration.

“Leave her alone,” he said. “She has been a graduate for six minutes.”

“Exactly,” Ma replied. “Now she can start looking for work.”

“I am looking for work.”

“You applied to three jobs.”

“Five.”

“Two rejected you.”

“That still counts as applying.”

Jun handed me my bag. “Can we take one picture before this becomes a family meeting?”

We stood near the university sign while students in black gowns crowded around us. Most of them looked young enough to be my children, assuming I had made some terrible decisions in high school.

Ma adjusted my graduation hood.

“Stand straight.”

“I am standing straight.”

“No, you are standing tired.”

“I am tired.”

“Not in the picture.”

Jun raised his phone. “Ready?”

Mia stepped beside me and slipped her arm through mine.

“Move a little to the left,” she whispered.

“Why?”

“You’re blocking my good side.”

“You said you didn’t want to be in the picture.”

Her smile disappeared. “That doesn’t mean you should block me.”

“Ana,” Jun said, lowering the phone. “Who are you talking to?”

“Mia.”

He looked beside me.

Mia gave him a small wave.

“Where is she?” Jun asked.

“She’s right—”

“I don’t want a family picture,” Mia interrupted.

I sighed. “She stepped away.”

Jun glanced around. “I thought you said she came.”

“She did. She doesn’t like pictures.”

Ma frowned. “This Mia is very shy.”

“She’s not shy. She just doesn’t like family pictures.”

“That sounds worse,” Jun said.

“Can we please take the photo?”

Jun raised the phone again. Ma pulled me close. Mia remained on my other side, although she had refused to be included.

“Smile,” Jun said.

The phone clicked.

For a moment, the day felt exactly right. I had my degree in my hand. My family was proud of me. My future was unclear, but at least it had officially started.

Then Ma looked at me and asked, “So, when is your first interview?”

The feeling lasted less than a minute.

By the time Mia and I reached the apartment, my feet were swollen and my cheeks hurt from smiling.

Our building was old but clean, with narrow stairs and a metal gate that screeched every time it opened. The apartment was on the third floor. It had one bedroom, a small kitchen, and a living room just large enough for a sofa, a table, and Mia’s habit of leaving things wherever she pleased.

She unlocked the door while I carried the food.

“Could you help?” I asked.

“I opened the door.”

“You turned a key.”

“And now we are inside.”

I placed everything on the table. “You could have carried the pancit.”

“I was carrying your flowers.”

“You insisted on buying those.”

“They made you look successful.”

“They came from a stall outside the university gate.”

“Success doesn’t need to know that.”

Mia dropped onto the sofa and removed her shoes.

There was one mug in the sink, three unpaid bills on the table, and a basket of laundry I had been avoiding since Tuesday. My degree sat in its folder beside a packet of soy sauce.

Graduation had not transformed anything.

Mia watched me staring around the apartment.

“Don’t start,” she said.

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You’re thinking loudly.”

“I thought today would feel different.”

“It is different. You have a degree.”

“And no job.”

“You had no job yesterday too. Today, you have a degree and no job. That is progress.”

My phone buzzed. Jun had sent me a message.

Send me your CV tonight. I’ll check it.

Mia leaned over the table to read it.

“Don’t send it.”

“Why?”

“He’ll rewrite everything and make you sound like a bank.”

“He works in a bank.”

“Exactly. Soon your hobbies will include risk management.”

“I need help.”

“You need confidence.”

“I need rent money.”

She looked toward the ceiling.

“Mia.”

“I heard you.”

“You said you would transfer your share last week.”

“I am waiting for money.”

“From where?”

“A source.”

“What source?”

“A private source.”

“You don’t have a private source.”

“That is why it is taking so long.”

I opened the container of pancit.

“You owe me fourteen thousand pesos.”

“That number feels exaggerated.”

“I wrote it down.”

“Writing something down doesn’t make it true.”

“That is exactly what makes it true.”

My phone rang before she could answer.

Ma.

I placed the phone on the table and answered on speaker.

“You reached home?” she asked.

“Yes, Ma.”

“And Mia?”

“She’s here.”

“Hello, Mia!” Ma called loudly.

Mia looked at the phone.

“Tell her I said hello.”

“You tell her.”

“I’m tired.”

“You’re sitting beside the phone.”

“She can’t hear me properly from here.”

“You’re less than two metres away.”

Ma went quiet.

“Ana?”

“Yes.”

“What are you doing?”

“Nothing. Mia says hello.”

“Bring her on Sunday.”

I looked at Mia.

She immediately shook her head.

“She might be busy,” I said.

“Doing what?”

Mia mouthed, *Work*.

“She has work.”

“On Sunday?”

“Sometimes.”

“What does she do again?”

I hesitated.

Mia had described her job as freelance consulting, online support, content work, and “a temporary transition between opportunities,” depending on the day.

“She works online.”

“Doing what online?”

“Ma, why are you interviewing me about Mia?”

“Because I have never met the woman living with my daughter.”

Mia leaned closer to the phone.

“Ana is tired, Tita Fe,” she said clearly. “We will call you tomorrow.”

Then she ended the call.

I stared at her.

“You hung up on my mother.”

“She was becoming invasive.”

“She’s going to call back.”

The phone rang immediately.

Mia handed it to me.

“See?”

I declined the call.

“You are a bad influence.”

“And yet you graduated.”

“I graduated because I studied.”

“I reminded you to study.”

“You watched cooking videos beside me.”

“That was background support.”

Me, Myself and Mia | Written: August 1, 2026 | Author: Daintyjha | Written for DigiCafe and Dainty Stories

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I placed two servings of pancit on the table. Mia sat across from me and began picking out the carrots.

For a while, neither of us spoke.

Outside, someone was singing karaoke badly. A motorcycle passed below. The neighbour's child ran through the hallway while a woman shouted his full name.

I looked at my degree.

"What if I don't find anything?" I asked.

Mia stopped moving the carrots around her plate.

"You will."

"You don't know that."

"I do."

"How?"

"Because you didn't spend four years studying just to sit here and complain about me."

"I complained about you before university."

"And you can continue after you become successful."

I smiled despite myself.

"Tomorrow," she said, "we go to the café. We fix your CV, apply for ten jobs, and order cake."

"We cannot afford cake."

"You graduated."

"That doesn't make cake free."

"It should."

"I'm serious."

"So am I. One day of celebration will not destroy you."

"You say that about every unnecessary expense."

“And have you been destroyed?”

“I have three unpaid bills.”

“Not destroyed. Slightly threatened.”

I laughed.

Mia pushed her unfinished plate toward me.

“You can have the rest.”

“You barely ate.”

“I’m full.”

“You always ask for food, eat three bites, and then give it to me.”

“You hate waste.”

“I also hate paying for two people.”

“We cannot solve every problem tonight.”

“That is convenient for you.”

She stood and walked toward the bedroom.

“Mia.”

She turned. “What?”

“You forgot your plate.”

She looked back at the table.

“That one is yours.”

“There are two.”

“You had two servings.”

“I did not.”

“You were hungry.”

I stared at the plates, trying to remember.

My phone buzzed before I could answer.

It was an email.

Interview Invitation

I read it twice.

Then I shouted, “Mia!”

She hurried back into the room.

“What happened?”

I held up the phone.

“I have an interview.”

Her face lit up.

“I told you.”

“You didn’t know.”

“I knew enough.”

“It’s on Monday.”

“Good.”

“I have nothing to wear.”

“We’ll find something.”

“I’m terrible at interviews.”

“We’ll practise.”

“I might embarrass myself.”

“You probably will.”

“Mia.”

“But you may still get the job.”

I laughed, then covered my mouth because I was suddenly close to crying.

Mia came around the table and hugged me.

For once, she didn’t make a joke.

“You are not late, Ana,” she said quietly. “You just took the long way.”

I held on to her.

Outside, the karaoke singer missed another note.

Inside, my degree rested beside the soy sauce, my mother was probably complaining to Jun, and my housemate still owed me fourteen thousand pesos.

But I had an interview.

It was not success.

Not yet.

Still, it was somewhere to begin.